

Whilst indulging in these reflections Bundle continued to chat pleasantly. Herr Eberhard, she heard, had arrived, but was lying down with a nervous headache. This was told her by Mr O'Rourke, who managed to find a place by her side and keep it.

Altogether, Bundle went up to dress in a pleasant mood of expectation, with a slight nervous dread hovering in the background whenever she thought of the imminent arrival of Mrs Macatta. Bundle felt that dalliance with Mrs Macatta was going to prove no primrose path.

Her first shock was when she came down, demurely attired in a black lace frock, and passed along the hall. A footman was standing there—at least a man dressed as a footman. But that square, burly figure lent itself badly to the deception. Bundle stopped and stared.

'Superintendent Battle,' she breathed.

'That's right, Lady Eileen.'

'Oh!' said Bundle uncertainly. 'Are you here to—to—'

'Keep an eye on things.'

'I see.'

'That warning letter, you know,' said the Superintendent, 'fairly put the wind up Mr Lomax. Nothing would do for him but that I should come down myself.'

'But don't you think—' began Bundle, and stopped. She hardly liked to suggest to the Superintendent that his disguise was not a particularly efficient one. He seemed to have 'police officer' written all over him, and Bundle could hardly imagine the most unsuspecting criminal failing to be put on his guard.

'You think,' said the Superintendent stolidly, 'that I might be recognized?'

He gave the final word a distinct capital letter.

'I did think so—yes—' admitted Bundle.

Something that might conceivably have been intended for a smile crossed the woodenness of Superintendent Battle's features.

'Put them on their guard, eh? Well, Lady Eileen, why not?'

'Why not?' echoed Bundle, rather stupidly, she felt.

Superintendent Battle was nodding his head slowly.

'We don't want any unpleasantness, do we?' he said. 'Don't want to be too clever—just show any light-fingered gentry that may be about—well, just show them that there's somebody on the spot, so to speak.'

Bundle gazed at him in some admiration. She could imagine that the sudden appearance of so renowned a personage as Superintendent Battle might have a depressing effect on any scheme and the hatches of it.

'It's a great mistake to be too clever,' Superintendent Battle was repeating. 'The great thing is not to have any unpleasantness this week-end.'

Bundle passed on, wondering how many of her fellow guests had recognized or would recognize the Scotland Yard detective. In the drawing-room George was standing with a puckered brow and an orange envelope in his hand.

'Most vexatious,' he said. 'A telegram from Mrs Macatta to say she will be unable to be with us. Her children are suffering from mumps.'

Bundle's heart gave a throb of relief.

'I especially feel this on your account, Eileen,' said George kindly. 'I know how anxious you were to meet her. The Countess too will be sadly disappointed.'

'Oh, never mind,' said Bundle. 'I should hate it if she'd come and given me mumps.'

'A very distressing complaint,' agreed George. 'But I do not think that infection could be carried that way. Indeed, I am sure that Mrs Macatta would have run no risk of that kind. She is a most highly principled woman, with a very real sense of her responsibilities to the community. In these days of national stress, we must all take into account—'

On the brink of embarking on a speech, George pulled himself up short.

'But it must be for another time,' he said. 'Fortunately there is no hurry in your case. But the Countess, alas, is only a visitor to our shores.'

'She's a Hungarian, isn't she?' said Bundle, who was curious about the Countess.

'Yes. You have heard, no doubt, of the Young Hungarian party? The Countess is a leader in that party. A woman of great wealth, left a widow at an early age, she has devoted her money and her talents to public service. She has especially devoted herself to the problem of infant mortality—a terrible one under present conditions in Hungary. I—Ah! here is Herr Eberhard.'

The German inventor was younger than Bundle had imagined him. He was probably not more than thirty-three or four. He was boorish and ill at ease, and yet his personality was not an unpleasant one. His blue eyes were more shy than furtive, and his more unpleasant mannerisms, such as the one that

Bill had described of gnawing his finger-nails, arose, she thought, more from nervousness than from any other cause. He was thin and weedy in appearance and looked anaemic and delicate.

He conversed rather awkwardly with Bundle in stilted English and they both welcomed the interruption of the joyous Mr O'Rourke. Presently Bill bustled in—there is no other word for it. In the same such way does a favoured Newfoundland make his entrance, and at once came over to Bundle. He was looking perplexed and harassed.

'Hullo, Bundle. Heard you'd got here. Been kept with my nose to the grindstone all the blessed afternoon or I'd have seen you before.'

'Cares of State heavy to-night?' suggested O'Rourke sympathetically.

Bill groaned.

'I don't know what your fellow's like,' he complained. 'Looks a good-natured, tubby little chap. But Codders is absolutely impossible. Drive, drive, drive, from morning to night. Everything you do is wrong; and everything you haven't done you ought to have done.'

'Quite like a quotation from the prayer book,' remarked Jimmy, who had just strolled up.

Bill glanced at them reproachfully.

'Nobody knows,' he said pathetically, 'what I have to put up with.'

'Entertaining the Countess, eh?' suggested Jimmy. 'Poor Bill, that must have been a sad strain—to a woman hater like yourself.'

'What's this?' asked Bundle.

'After tea,' said Jimmy with a grin, 'the Countess asked Bill to show her round the interesting old place.'

'Well, I couldn't refuse, could I?' said Bill, his countenance assuming a brick-red tint.

Bundle felt faintly uneasy. She knew, only too well, the susceptibility of Mr William Eversleigh to female charms. In the hands of a woman like the Countess, Bill would be as wax. She wondered once more whether Jimmy Thesiger had been wise to take Bill into their confidence.

'The Countess,' said Bill, 'is a very charming woman. And no end intelligent. You should have seen her going round the house. All sorts of questions she asked.'

'What kind of questions?' asked Bundle suddenly.

Countess Radzky had been conversing with Mr Bateman. Leaning very far back on a sofa, with her legs crossed in a daring manner, she was smoking a cigarette in an incredibly long turquoise-studded holder.

Bundle thought she was one of the most beautiful women she had ever seen. Her eyes were very large and blue, her hair was coal black, she had a matte skin, the slightly flattened nose of the Slav, and a sinuous, slender body. Her lips were reddened to a degree with which Bundle was sure Wyvern Abbey was totally unacquainted.

She said eagerly: 'This is Mrs Macatra—yes?'

On George's replying in the negative and introducing Bundle, the Countess gave her a careless nod, and at once resumed her conversation with the serious Mr Bateman.

Bundle heard Jimmy's voice in her ear:

'Pongo is absolutely fascinated by the lovely Slav,' he said. 'Pathetic, isn't it? Come and have some tea.'

They drifted once more into the neighbourhood of Sir Oswald Coote.

'That's a fine place of yours, Chimneys,' remarked the great man.

'I'm glad you liked it,' said Bundle meekly.

'Wants new plumbing,' said Sir Oswald. 'Bring it up to date, you know.'

He ruminated for a minute or two.

'I'm taking the Duke of Alton's place. Three years. Just while I'm looking round for a place of my own. Your father couldn't sell if he wanted to, I suppose.'

Bundle felt her breath taken away. She had a nightmare vision of England with innumerable Cootes in innumerable counterparts of Chimneys—all, be it understood, with an entirely new system of plumbing installed.

She felt a sudden violent resentment which, she told herself, was absurd. After all, contrasting Lord Caterham with Sir Oswald Coote, there was no doubt as to who would go to the wall. Sir Oswald had one of those powerful personalities which make all those with whom they come in contact appear faded. He was, as Lord Caterham had said, a human steam-roller. And yet, undoubtedly, in many ways, Sir Oswald was a stupid man. Apart from his special line of knowledge and his terrific driving force, he was probably intensely ignorant. A hundred delicate appreciations of life which Lord Caterham could and did enjoy were a sealed book to Sir Oswald.

'Not mentally very agile?' suggested Jimmy. 'But you forget one thing—Bill's got a very hefty fist. And I've an idea that a hefty fist is going to come in handy.'

'Well, perhaps you're right. How did he take it?'

'Well, he clutched his head a good bit, but—I mean the facts took some driving home. But by repeating the thing patiently in words of one syllable I at last got it into his thick head. And, naturally, he's with us to the death, as you might say.'

George reappeared suddenly.

'I must make some introductions, Eileen. This is Sir Stanley Digby—Lady Eileen Brent. Mr O'Rourke.' The Air Minister was a little round man with a cheerful smile. Mr O'Rourke, a tall young man with laughing blue eyes and a typical Irish face, greeted Bundle with enthusiasm.

'And I thinking it was going to be a dull political party entirely,' he murmured in an adroit whisper.

'Hush,' said Bundle. 'I'm political—very political.'

'Sir Oswald and Lady Coote you know,' continued George.

'We've never actually met,' said Bundle, smiling.

She was mentally applauding her father's descriptive powers.

Sir Oswald took her hand in an iron grip and she winced slightly.

Lady Coote, after a somewhat mournful greeting, had turned to Jimmy Thesiger, and appeared to be registering something closely akin to pleasure. Despite his reprehensible habit of being late for breakfast, Lady Coote had a fondness for this amiable, pink-faced young man. His air of irrepressible good nature fascinated her. She had a motherly wish to cure him of his bad habits and form him into one of the world's workers. Whether, once formed, he would be as attractive was a question she had never asked herself. She began now to tell him of a very painful motor accident which had happened to one of her friends.

'Mr Bateman,' said George briefly, as one who would pass on to better things.

A serious, pale-faced young man bowed.

'And now,' continued George, 'I must introduce you to Countess Radzky.'

Bill was vague. 'Oh! I don't know. About the history of it. And old furniture. And—oh! all sorts of things.'

At that moment the Countess swept into the room. She seemed a shade breathless. She was looking magnificent in a close-fitting black velvet gown. Bundle noticed how Bill gravitated at once into her immediate neighbourhood. The serious, spectacled young man joined him.

'Bill and Pongo have both got it badly,' observed Jimmy Thesiger with a laugh.

Bundle was by no means so sure that it was a laughing matter.

Chapter XVI

The House Party at the Abbey

BUNDLE drove over to Wyvern Abbey just in time for tea on Friday afternoon. George Lomax came forward to welcome her with considerable *empressment*.

‘My dear Eileen,’ he said, ‘I can’t tell you how pleased I am to see you here. You must forgive my not having invited you when I asked your father, but to tell the truth I never dreamed that a party of this kind would appeal to you. I was both—er—surprised and—er—delighted when Lady Caterham told me of your—er—interest in—er—politics.’

‘I wanted to come so much,’ said Bundle in a simple, ingenuous manner.

‘Mrs Macatta will not arrive till the later train,’ explained George. ‘She was speaking at a meeting in Manchester last night. Do you know Thesiger? Quite a young fellow, but a remarkable grasp of foreign politics. One would hardly suspect it from his appearance.’

‘I know Mr Thesiger,’ said Bundle, and she shook hands solemnly with Jimmy, whom she observed had parted his hair in the middle in the endeavour to add earnestness to his expression.

‘Look here,’ said Jimmy in a low hurried voice, as George temporarily withdrew. ‘You mustn’t be angry, but I’ve told Bill about our little stunt.’

‘Bill?’ said Bundle, annoyed.

‘Well, after all,’ said Jimmy, ‘Bill is one of the lads, you know. Rommy was a pal of his and so was Gerry.’

‘Oh! I know,’ said Bundle.

‘But you think it’s a pity? Sorry.’

‘Bill’s all right, of course. It isn’t that,’ said Bundle. ‘But he’s—well, Bill’s a born blunderer.’

'It's me—Jimmy. I thought you'd like to know the result of the inquest. Death by misadventure.'

'Oh, but—'

'Yes, but I think there's something behind that. The coroner had had a hint.'

'Someone's at work to hush it up. I say, Loraine—'

'Yes?'

'Look here. There's—there's some funny business going about. You'll be very careful, won't you? For my sake.'

He heard the quick note of alarm that sprang into her voice.

'Jimmy—but then it's dangerous—for *you*.'

He laughed.

'Oh, *that's* all right. I'm the cat that had nine lives. Bye-bye, old thing.'

He rang off and remained a minute or two lost in thought. Then he summoned Stevens.

'Do you think you could go out and buy me a pistol, Stevens?'

'A pistol, sir?'

'True to his training, Stevens betrayed no hint of surprise.'

'What kind of a pistol would you be requiring?'

'The kind where you put your finger on the trigger and the thing goes on shooting until you take it off again.'

'An automatic, sir.'

'That's it,' said Jimmy. 'An automatic. And I should like it to be a blue-nosed one—if you and the shopman know what that is. In American stories, the hero always takes his blue-nosed automatic from his hip pocket.'

Stevens permitted himself a faint, discreet smile.

'Most American gentlemen that I have known, sir, carry something very different in their hip pockets,' he observed.

Jimmy Thesiger laughed.

Chapter XVII

After Dinner

GEOGE was not a believer in modern innovations. The Abbey was innocent of anything so up to date as central heating. Consequently, when the ladies entered the drawing-room after dinner, the temperature of the room was woefully inadequate to the needs of modern evening clothes. The fire that burnt in the well-burnished steel grate became as a magnet. The three women huddled round it.

'Brrrrrrrrrr!' said the Countess, a fine, exotic, foreign sound.

'The days are drawing in,' said Lady Coote, and drew a flowered atrocity of a scarf closer about her ample shoulders.

'Why on earth doesn't George have the house properly heated?' said Bundle.

'You English, you never heat your houses,' said the Countess.

She took out her long cigarette holder and began to smoke.

'That grate is old-fashioned,' said Lady Coote. 'The heat goes up the chimney instead of into the room.'

'Oh!' said the Countess.

There was a pause. The Countess was so plainly bored by her company that conversation became difficult.

'It's funny,' said Lady Coote, breaking the silence, 'that Mrs Macatra's children should have mumps. At least, I don't mean exactly funny—'

'What,' said the Countess, 'are mumps?'

Bundle and Lady Coote started simultaneously to explain. Finally, between them, they managed it.

'I suppose Hungarian children have it?' asked Lady Coote.

'Eh?' said the Countess.

'Hungarian children. They suffer from it?'

'I do not know,' said the Countess. 'How should I?'

Lady Coote looked at her in some surprise.

'But I understood that you worked—'

'Oh, that!' The Countess uncrossed her legs, took her cigarette holder from her mouth and began to talk rapidly.

'I will tell you some horrors,' she said. 'Horror that I have seen. Incredible! You would not believe!'

And she was as good as her word. She talked fluently and with a graphic power of description. Incredible scenes of starvation and misery were painted by her for the benefit of her audience. She spoke of Buda Pesth shortly after the war and traced its vicissitudes to the present day. She was dramatic, but she was also, to Bundle's mind, a little like a gramophone record. You turned her on, and there you were. Presently, just as suddenly, she would stop.

Lady Coote was thrilled to the marrow—that much was clear. She sat with her mouth slightly open and her large, sad, dark eyes fixed on the Countess. Occasionally, she interpolated a comment of her own.

'One of my cousins had three children burned to death. Awful, wasn't it?' The Countess paid no attention. She went on and on. And she finally stopped as suddenly as she had begun.

'There!' she said. 'I have told you! We have money—but no organization. It is organization we need.'

Lady Coote sighed.

'I've heard my husband say that nothing can be done without regular methods. He attributes his own success entirely to that. He declares he would have never got on without them.'

She sighed again. A sudden fleeting vision passed before her eyes of a Sir Oswald who had not got on in the world. A Sir Oswald who retained, in all essentials, the attributes of that cheery young man in the bicycle shop. Just for a second it occurred to her how much pleasanter life might have been for her if Sir Oswald had *not* had regular methods.

By a quite understandable association of ideas she turned to Bundle.

'Tell me, Lady Eileen,' she said, 'do you like that head gardener of yours?'

'MacDonald? Well—' Bundle hesitated. 'One couldn't exactly *like* MacDonald,' she explained apologetically. 'But he's a first-class gardener.'

'Oh! I know he is,' said Lady Coote.

'There's the woman, of course,' continued Jimmy. 'She ought to be easier. But then, you're not likely to run across her. She's probably putting in the dirty work being taken out to dinner by amorous Cabinet Ministers and getting State secrets out of them when they've had a couple. At least, that's how it's done in books. As a matter of fact, the only Cabinet Minister I know drinks hot water with a dash of lemon in it.'

'Take George Lomax, for instance, can you imagine him being amorous with beautiful foreign women?' said Bundle with a laugh.

Jimmy agreed with her criticism.

'And now about the man of mystery—No 7,' went on Jimmy. 'You've no idea who he could be?'

'None whatever.'

'Again—by book standard, that is—he ought to be someone we all know. What about George Lomax himself?'

Bundle reluctantly shook her head.

'In a book, it would be perfect,' she agreed. 'But knowing Codders—' And she gave herself up to a sudden uncontrollable mirth. 'Codders, the great criminal organizer,' she gasped. 'Wouldn't it be marvellous?'

Jimmy agreed that it would. Their discussion had taken some time and his driving had slowed down involuntarily once or twice. They arrived at Chimneys, to find Colonel Melrose already there waiting. Jimmy was introduced to him and they all three proceeded to the inquest together.

As Colonel Melrose had predicted, the whole affair was very simple. Bundle gave her evidence. The doctor gave his. Evidence was given of rifle practice in the neighbourhood. A verdict of death by misadventure was brought in.

After the proceedings were over, Colonel Melrose volunteered to drive Bundle back to Chimneys, and Jimmy Thesiger returned to London. For all his lighthearted manner, Bundle's story had impressed him profoundly. He set his lips closely together.

'Romney, old boy,' he murmured, 'I'm going to be up against it. And you're not here to join in the game.'

Another thought flashed into his mind. Lorraine! Was she in danger?

After a minute or two's hesitation, he went over to the telephone and rang her up.

'That's it,' said Bundle eagerly. 'You must be right, Jimmy. Eberhard must have offered his invention to our Government. They've been taking, or are going to take, Sir Oswald Coote's expert opinion on it. There's going to be an unofficial conference at the Abbey. Sir Oswald, George, the Air Minister and Eberhard. Eberhard will have the plans or the process or whatever you call it—'

'Formula,' suggested Jimmy. 'I think 'formula' is a good word myself.'

'He'll have the formula with him, and the Seven Dials are out to steal the formula. I remember the Russian saying it was worth millions.'

'I suppose it would be,' said Jimmy.

'And well worth a few lives—that's what the other man said.'

'Well, it seems to have been,' said Jimmy, his face clouding over. 'Look at this damned inquest to-day. Bundle, are you sure Ronny said nothing else?'

'No,' said Bundle. 'Just that. *Seven Dials. Tell Jimmy Thestiger*. That's all he could get out, poor lad.'

'I wish we knew what he knew,' said Jimmy. 'But we've found out one thing. I take it that the footman, Bauer, must almost certainly have been responsible for Gerry's death. You know, Bundle—'

'Yes?'

'Well, I'm a bit worried sometimes. Who's going to be the next one! It really isn't the sort of business for a girl to be mixed up in.'

Bundle smiled in spite of herself. It occurred to her that it had taken Jimmy a long time to put her in the same category as Lorraine Wade.

'It's far more likely to be you than me,' she remarked cheerfully.

'Hear, hear,' said Jimmy. 'But what about a few casualties on the other side for a change? I'm feeling rather bloodthirsty this morning. Tell me, Bundle, would you recognize any of these people if you saw them?'

Bundle hesitated.

'I think I should recognize № 5,' she said at last. 'He's got a queer way of speaking—a kind of venomous, hissing way—that I think I'd know again.'

'What about the Englishman?'

Bundle shook her head.

'I saw him least—only a glimpse—and he's got a very ordinary voice. Except that he's a big man, there's nothing much to go by.'

'He's all right if he's kept in his place,' said Bundle. 'I suppose so,' said Lady Coote. She looked enviously at Bundle, who appeared to approach the task of keeping MacDonald in his place so light heartedly.

'I'd just adore a high-toned garden,' said the Countess dreamily.

Bundle stared, but at that moment a diversion occurred. Jimmy Thestiger entered the room and spoke directly to her in a strange, hurried voice.

'I say, will you come and see those etchings now? They're waiting for you.' Bundle left the room hurriedly, Jimmy close behind her.

'What etchings?' she asked, as the drawing-room door closed behind her.

'No etchings,' said Jimmy. 'I'd got to say something to get hold of you. Come on, Bill is waiting for us in the library. There's nobody there.'

Bill was striding up and down the library, clearly in a very perturbed state of mind.

'Look here,' he burst out, 'I don't like this.'

'Don't like what?'

'You being mixed up in this. Ten to one there's going to be a rough house and then—'

He looked at her with a kind of pathetic dismay that gave Bundle a warm and comfortable feeling.

'She ought to be kept out of it, oughtn't she, Jimmy?'

He appealed to the other.

'I've told her so,' said Jimmy.

'Dash it all, Bundle, I mean—someone might get hurt.'

Bundle turned round to Jimmy.

'How much have you told him?'

'Oh! everything.'

'I haven't got the hang of it all yet,' confessed Bill. 'You in that place in Seven Dials and all that.' He looked at her unhappily. 'I say, Bundle, I wish you wouldn't.'

'Wouldn't what?'

'Get mixed up in these sorts of things.'

'Why not?' said Bundle. 'They're exciting.'

'Oh, yes—exciting. But they may be damnably dangerous. Look at poor old Ronny.'

'Yes,' said Bundle. 'If it hadn't been for your friend Ronny, I don't suppose I should ever have got what you call 'mixed up' in this thing. But I am. And it's no earthly use your bleating about it.'

'I know you're the most frightful sport, Bundle, but—'

'Cut out the compliments. Let's make plans.'

To her relief, Bill reacted favourably to the suggestion.

'You're right about the formula,' he said. 'Eberhard's got some sort of formula with him, or rather Sir Oswald has. The stuff has been tested out at his works—very secretly and all that. Eberhard has been down there with him. They're all in the study now—what you might call coming down to brass tacks.'

'How long is Sir Stanley Digby staying?' asked Jimmy.

'Going back to town to-morrow.'

'H'm,' said Jimmy. 'Then one thing's quite clear. If, as I suppose, Sir Stanley will be taking the formula with him, any funny business there's going to be will be to-night.'

'I suppose it will.'

'Not a doubt of it. That narrows the thing down very comfortably. But the bright lads will have to be their very brightest. We must come down to details. First of all, where will the sacred formula be to-night? Will Eberhard have it, or Sir Oswald Coote?'

'Neither. I understand it's to be handed over to the Air Minister this evening, for him to take to town to-morrow. In that case O'Rourke will have it. Sure to.'

'Well, there's only one thing for it. If we believe someone's going to have a shot at pinching that paper, we've got to keep watch to-night, Bill, my boy.' Bundle opened her mouth as though to protest, but shut it again without speaking.

'By the way,' continued Jimmy, 'did I recognize the commissioner from Harrods in the hall this evening, or was it our old friend Lestrade from Scotland Yard?'

'Scintillating, Watson,' said Bill.

'I suppose,' said Jimmy, 'that we are rather butting in on his preserves.' 'Can't be helped,' said Bill. 'Not if we mean to see this thing through.' 'Then it's agreed,' said Jimmy. 'We divide the night into two watches?'

'Oh!' said Jimmy slowly. 'You think—'

'The absent № 2 is Bauer—our footman. That seems to me quite clear from what they said about expecting a report which hadn't come in—though what there can be to report about Chimneys, I can't think.'

'It must be something to do with Gerry Wade's death,' said Jimmy. 'There's something there we haven't fathomed yet. You say they actually mentioned Bauer by name?'

Bundle nodded.

'They blamed him for not having found that letter.'

'Well, I don't see what you could have clearer than that. There's no going against it. You'll have to forgive my first incredulity, Bundle—but you know, it was rather a tall story. You say they knew about my going down to Wyyvern Abbey next week?'

'Yes, that's when the American—it was him, not the Russian—said they needn't worry—you were only the usual kind of ass.'

'Ah!' said Jimmy. He pressed his foot down on the accelerator viciously and the car shot forward. 'I'm very glad you told me that. It gives me what you might call a personal interest in the case.'

He was silent for a minute or two and then he said:

'Did you say that German inventor's name was Eberhard?'

'Yes. Why?'

'Wait a minute. Something's coming back to me. Eberhard, Eberhard—yes, I'm sure that was the name.'

'Tell me.'

'Eberhard was a Johnny who'd got some patent process he applied to steel. I can't put the thing properly because I haven't got the scientific knowledge—but I know the result was that it became so toughened that a wire was as strong as a steel bar had previously been. Eberhard had to do with aeroplanes and his idea was that the weight would be so enormously reduced that flying would be practically revolutionized—the cost of it, I mean. I believe he offered his invention to the German Government, and they turned it down, pointed out some undeniable flaw in it—but they did it rather nastily. He set to work and circumvented the difficulty, whatever it was, but he'd been offended by their attitude and swore they shouldn't have his ewe lamb. I always thought the whole thing was probably bunkum, but now—it looks differently.'